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SFB 1718 Common Ground

De-Polarization
New Practices of Invitational
(Science) Communication

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(De-)Polarization Strategies

A View from Rhetoric and Linguistics

1 Goals & research questions

▷ Rhetorical–linguistic text-based analyses of naturally occurring corpus data, focusing on rhetorical maneuvers, linguistic constructions, and results from linguistic experiments

Hypothesis:

Rhetorical and linguistic strategies related to common ground (such as presupposition, deletion, ambiguation, and emotionalization) fuel and mitigate polarization

Goals:

i. Description of (non)cooperative discourse strategies in polarized political discourse
ii. Focus on the interaction of linguistic and rhetorical factors that lead to polarization
iii. Generalizations from empirical studies for CG model

Research questions:

1. Which strategies trigger the construction of CG and which destroy it?
2. How is CG constructed in polarized political discourse? And how can the process of CG construction within one group and polarization against another be described?
3. How can this type of multiplicity of CG (in- vs. outgroup) be modeled?

Scientific advancement:
Connection between polarization and common ground; modeling of non-idealized political discourse

2 Polarization and de-polarization strategies

A **strategy** is the speaker's calculation of *ends*, *resistance*, and *means* (Knape et al. 2009)

Definition

[Polarization is] a *rhetorical strategy* that involves using specific textual structures in appropriate contexts to divide an audience into two mutually exclusive and diametrically opposed opinion groups: a positive, virtuous in-group and a negative, evil out-group. (Fortuna 2019: 3)

- Strengthening in-group identity (*bonding*) ⇔ distancing from out-group (Dryzek 2010; van Dijk 2024)
- Rhetorical maneuvers of *identification* & *demarcation*

3 Strategic linguistic devices

3.1 Strategic presupposition

- Smuggling propositions into CG
- Plausible deniability
- Shallow processing? (Lombardi Vallauri 2021)

(1) And I was told by *the real pollsters* – we do have real pollsters – they know that we were going to do well and we were going to win. (D. J. Trump, 6 January 2021)

3.2 Strategic deletion

- Avoidance of problematic terms
- Veiled threats/indirect speech acts
- Creation of local ambiguities → recovery of elided material not always unambiguous

(2) a. You disarm, *or we will*. (G. W. Bush, 5 October 2022)
b. If they [Hamas] don't disarm, we will disarm them. (D. J. Trump, 14 October 2025)

(3) Let me say again – to any country, any organization, anyone thinking of taking advantage of this situation, I have one word: *Don't. Don't.* (J. Biden, 10 October 2023)

3.3 Strategic ambiguation

- Creation of ambiguous structures
- Plausible deniability for problematic content
- Triggering different CG updates for different sub-audiences

(4) You know, America is blessed with elections. All over the world they talk about our elections. You know what the world says about us now? They said, we don't have free and fair elections. *And you know what else [. . .]?* We don't have a free and fair press. (D. J. Trump, 6 January 2021)

3.4 Strategic emotionalization

- Bypass rational reflection
- Triggering automatic affective responses
- Strenghten in-group identity in opposition to out-group (Dryzek 2010; van Dijk 2024; Bächtiger & Dryzek 2024)

(5) We all agree that we live in a vulnerable, rather fragile, but interconnected world. A world where, whether you like it or not, you have to co-exist with each other. Whatever divides us, we share the same planet. Europe is our common home. *A home, not a 'theatre of war'*. (M. Gorbachev, 18 December 1984)

4 Strategies of depolarization?

- If polarization is a strategy, is there also a strategy of de-polarization?
- If so: does de-polarization use the same strategies?
- Dryzek (2010): *bonding* vs. *bridging* rhetoric

(6) But I know this: If we do the hard work of working together as Americans, if we remain *united in purpose*, we will be prepared for whatever comes next. (K. Harris, 11 September 2021)

5 Two case studies

▷ **Strategic communication in polarized political discourse**

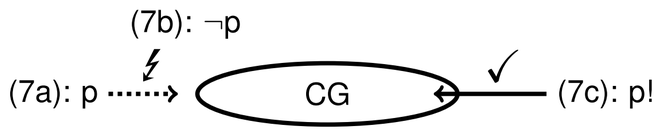
(7) a. DJT: In Springfield, they're eating the dogs. [. . .] they're eating the pets of the people that live there.
b. David Muir: [. . .] there have been no credible reports of specific claims of pets being harmed, injured or abused by individuals within the immigrant community.
c. DJT: The people on television say my dog was taken and used for food. (TV debate Trump & Harris, 10 September 2024)

Hypothesis:

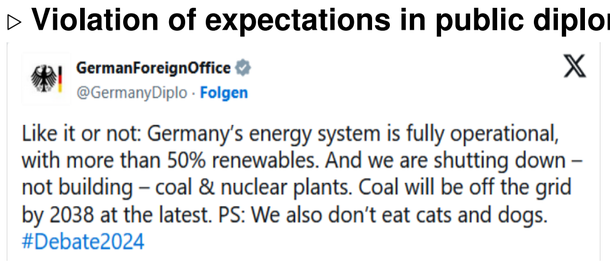
Repetition updates CG for a sub-audience and fuels polarization

- Presuppositions: pronouns, participle, racial topic
- Emotionally charged expressions: *pets*
- Update *p* in (7a) blocked by refusal in (7b)
- (7c) puts *p* back on the table
- Repetition updates CG for a sub-audience
- Result: polarized CG via non-cooperative CG update

(8)



▷ **Violation of expectations in public diplomacy**



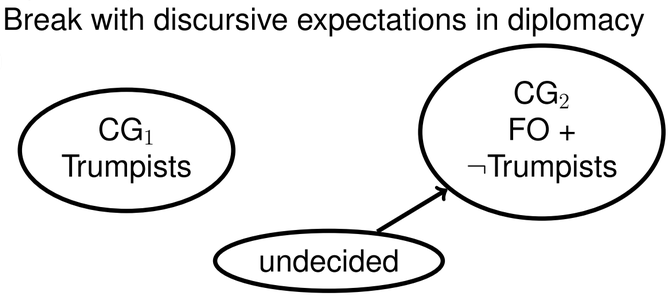
(Auswärtiges Amt, 11 September 2024)

Hypothesis:

Response to polarized statement 'cats and dogs' increases polarization by rhetorically constructing common ground.

- (Negative) emotionalization, demarcation and indirect attack through antithetical construction, allusion and ridicule
- Construction and access to in-group CG in public diplomacy
- Break with discursive expectations in diplomacy

(9)



Selected references

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